

Elements of a Successful Therapeutic Relationship

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Throughout the eight-week course, there has been discussion about multiple elements of a successful counseling relationship. Some of these elements include how the counselor presents themselves such as their body language, the environment they create, the questions they ask, and their ability to build rapport with their client. Counselors play a crucial role in the lives of their clients; it may be the only time that their client feels heard and understood. It may be the only time that their client can truly express themselves freely and be completely vulnerable.

Counseling and its elements is a responsibility that is placed on counselors' shoulders, and it is one that should be well thought out and practiced.

Counselor's Role

As a clinical mental health counselor, the role involves multiple responsibilities within the agency, school, or community setting, which are aimed at supporting individuals' emotional, psychological, and social well-being (Egan & Reese, 2019). They have a role in helping the client build social support networks in both their homes and their community. Communities frequently experience the impact of traumatic events like violence, drug and sex trafficking, police shootings, crime, substance abuse, and child abuse or neglect. As a licensed professional counselor, a primary focus is working with children and adolescents who have significant trauma backgrounds. They offer trauma therapy, specifically trauma-focused cognitive behavioral therapy, to help them heal. Additionally, counselors collaborate with local organizations, such as day care centers, to provide trauma education and help educators better understand how trauma affects young children (Takakjy, 2020). Counselors do not work alone, in fact they often work closely with psychiatrists, social workers, school counselors, and other professionals to take a dynamic approach and help their client in all aspects of their life.

Counselors also go through intensive training to become qualified and licensed in their chosen field. Doing so gives them the credibility they need to be professional counselors. I hope to play my role well as I finish up this program and move on to counseling in a professional setting. I hope to continue displaying the skills and characteristics of a successful counselor in both my personal and professional life.

Identity Development Strategies

One important step to becoming a professional counselor is to develop our own professional identity. Developing a strong counselor identity that fosters leadership, advocacy, and provides services for individuals with mental health issues requires intentional strategies that combine professional growth, community engagement, and ethical practice. An area where counselors in training and new counselors struggle in is feeling competent, confident in their skills, and clarifying their role as a counselor (Toubassi et al., 2023). Professional identity refers to the development of a sense of self that evolves over time, during which an individual adopts the traits, values, and standards of their profession. This process leads to the person thinking, behaving, and feeling in line with the role of a counselor (Toubassi et al., 2023). Developing your professional identity is ongoing, a continuous cycle of growth and learning. It started back when I decided to go into this field and will continue to grow and progress as I work as a professional counselor. Some important strategies to help develop this identity is to ask questions. Ask questions to people who have been in the field for a long-time about certain areas of counseling that either are confusing or interest you. A counselor must be open and willing to change during this process. They also must continue to pursue knowledge, be open-minded while learning new skills, and must engage in regular self-care to avoid burn out (Toubassi et al., 2023).

Counselor Dispositions

The GCU counselor dispositions are areas in which counselors should either develop or improve on during their time as a counselor in training. One of the most important dispositions is that of Empathy. Displaying empathy was one of our main focal points during this course that we were to utilize while doing our mock sessions. I learned something about empathy that I won't forget, empathy is not about showing sorrow or pity towards an individual, it's about showing them that you understand them and why they feel a certain way. I showed empathy in the mock sessions by actively listening to my client and letting them know that I understood how or why they felt the way they did and that it made sense. For example, my client was struggling with a feeling of anxiety that because things in his life were going well, he was waiting for everything to fall apart. When he told me that, I told him that I understand why he is anxious for all of it to fall apart because when things are good, we have more to lose. I then followed up by letting him know that the feeling of anxiety he was experiencing was completely normal and it's a part of being human. Another disposition that I tried to include in my mock sessions was genuineness. I struggled with this concept at first because I wanted to make sure I hit all the points in the session for credit. Finally, during my final session, I tried to forget about all the points and just focused on being present in the moment and I felt that I was much more genuine, and my client felt the same. Lastly, I tried to implement flexibility into the sessions. Although my client was a friend of mine, we didn't come up with a pre-determined situation or script, I was flexible in that I went in there and tried my best to adapt to the situation.

Mock Session Reflection

As I reflected on the past 3 mock sessions, one common aspect that I felt came natural for me was SOLER skills. Counseling self-efficacy is an important metric for assessing trainees'

confidence in their counseling abilities (Hunsmann et al., 20204). I'm naturally a good listener, although practicing active listening has helped me hone my skills. I sat up straight and maintained eye contact through most of the sessions. In addition, I frequently nodded my head and offered minimal encouragers. I have always been accepting of others as well, it doesn't matter to me where you come from, what you believe in, or what you are struggling with, I see you as a human being that came to me for help. One area of improvement is my ability to ask open-ended questions on top of holding myself back from offering advice while the client is speaking. I need to let them first speak freely, and I need only to listen. One example from a mock session is when I tried to suggest a new possible coping mechanism. Instead of suggesting it or asking if my client had previously tried this mechanism, I offered my advice instead which is not part of empathetic listening and questioning.

Theory and Supervision

Theory plays a crucial role in developing a personal model of counseling by providing a structured framework for understanding human behavior, emotional challenges, and the therapeutic process (Bartle-Haring et al., 2022). Theory provides us with an evidence-based framework from which we can build off and create our own personal model of counseling. What I mean by that is, taking parts of different theories and bringing them together to form a model that works not only for my clients, but also something that I fully understand. Theory is good for our foundational knowledge, but creating our model puts that knowledge into practice.

I will take advantage of supervision as much as possible. I want to be successful, and I want to build a good name for myself and my work. Because of these goals, I will constantly ask questions and continue gain new knowledge and be open to criticism to help me create my

personal identity. I want to learn more, so who better to learn from than someone who has been there and done that.

Conclusion

In conclusion, effective counseling relies on the implementation of skills, identity development, and theoretical practice. Mastering core counseling skills, such as active listening, empathy, and reflective responses, equips counselors to create safe, supportive environments for clients. My professional identity will be shaped by continuous self-awareness, ethical practice, and a continuation of education. Dispositions like empathy, genuineness, and flexibility enhance therapeutic relationships, while a firm grasp of counseling theories informs the approach to client challenges, offering a framework to help build a counseling model. Together, these elements form the foundation of a competent, responsive, and impactful counselor.

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